

The Long Way Round

His wife had been lost for three years. She was in the same house. The search was not the kind he had been trained for.

CEFR Level B2

Book 8 of 10 • Family Drama / Memory / Illness • Adult Graded Reader Series

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About This Book

Setting: A house in suburban London. Memory clinics. The spaces between what is remembered and what is lost.

Genre: Family Drama / Memory / Illness

Characters

- Peter — 68. Retired civil engineer. His wife Margaret has had Alzheimer's for three years.
- Margaret — 66. His wife. Present in fragments, absent in others.
- Carla — 41. Their daughter. Concerned, guilty, geographically distant.
- The disease itself — the real antagonist, characterised throughout by its effects.

THE LONG WAY ROUND

Page 1 — Tuesday

The thing about Tuesdays was that Margaret sometimes knew what day it was.

This was not consistent — there were weeks when Tuesday was as opaque to her as any other day, when the demarcations of the week had been dissolved by whatever the disease did to the architecture of time.

But there were other Tuesdays — unpredictably spaced, impossible to anticipate — when she would say, at breakfast, 'It's Tuesday,' with the particular satisfaction of someone who had arrived, after a difficult journey, at a place they had been trying to reach.

Peter had learned to treat these Tuesdays carefully, neither capitalising on them nor drawing attention to them, since both responses tended to produce anxiety rather than comfort.

Vocabulary Support

demarcation	sınır çizgisi
opaque	opak, anlamsız
architecture of time	zamanın mimarisi
capitalising on	fırsatçılık etmek
anticipate	öngörmek

dissolved

çözölmüş

*Tuesdays when she knew. He had learned to treat them carefully.
The disease had taught him this.*

Page 2 — Three Years

The diagnosis had come three years ago.

It had come — as he had since understood was common — not as a surprise but as a name given to something that had already been happening for longer than they had acknowledged.

The acknowledgement had been its own form of grief: the realisation that the slight confusions, the small losses of place and time, the occasional repetitions that he had attributed to tiredness or distraction, had been, in fact, the early cartography of a territory he had not wanted to map.

He had spent three years learning to live in that territory.

He had not, in any sense that felt adequate, succeeded.

Vocabulary Support

diagnosis	teşhis
cartography	haritalama
territory	alan, bölge
acknowledged	kabul etti
attributed to	... e bağlamak
adequate	yeterli

The early symptoms he had attributed to tiredness. He had not wanted to map that territory.

Page 3 — What She Retained

He had come to think of the disease as a form of selective editing — one that bore no relationship to the logic of significance that he would have applied.

What Margaret retained was not what he would have predicted: not the major events, not the landmarks that had structured their forty-two years together.

She retained, instead, particular music — three or four songs she could still sing from beginning to end. She retained the names and faces of her grandchildren.

She retained something harder to name — a quality of warmth in company, an instinctive social grace, that survived her loss of narrative.

She retained the garden.

She could name plants she could no longer have told him she recognised from anywhere else.

Vocabulary Support

selective editing	seçici düzenleme
landmark	dönüm noktası
narrative	anlatı
instinctive social grace	içgüdüsel sosyal zarafet
retained	korudu

predicted	tahmin etmişti
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She retained music. Grandchildren. Social grace. The garden. Not what he would have predicted.

Page 4 — Carla

Their daughter Carla lived in Edinburgh and came down, when she came, with the concentrated attention of someone who understood that her presence was not sufficient but that it was what she had.

Peter had, in the early years, found Carla's visits difficult in ways that were hard to explain without sounding either ungrateful or cruel.

The visits brought disruption to the routines he had built with considerable care; Margaret was, for several days before and after, more agitated than usual; and Carla's distress — genuine, undisguised, and occasionally focused on Peter in ways that suggested she held him partially responsible for the state of things — added a layer of emotional management he was not always equipped to provide.

He had not said any of this to Carla.

He thought: she is doing her best.

He thought: so am I.

Vocabulary Support

concentrated attention	yoğun dikkat
disruption	bozulma, aksama
agitated	ajite, huzursuz

undisguised	gizlenmemiş
partially responsible	kısmen sorumlu
equipped	donanımlı

"She is doing her best. So am I." He has not said this. He thinks it instead.

Page 5 — The Routines

He had built the routines over three years with a precision that he recognised as an extension of his engineering training and which, he suspected, had also protected him from having to acknowledge certain things during the time he spent implementing them.

Breakfast at eight. The garden at nine-thirty, weather permitting. Lunch at twelve-thirty. The afternoon rest. The news, which she could no longer follow but from which she seemed to draw comfort from familiarity of sound.

He had read enough about the disease to know that consistency of environment reduced the frequency and severity of certain kinds of distress. The routines were, in the first instance, for her benefit.

He had come to understand that they were also, in a secondary way, for his.

Vocabulary Support

implementing	uygulamak
consistency of environment	çevrenin tutarlılığı
severity	şiddet, ağırlık
precision	kesinlik
in the first instance	öncelikle

protect from acknowledging	kabul etmekten korumak
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The routines were for her. He had come to understand they were also for him.

Page 6 — The Good Days

The good days were, in some ways, harder than the bad days.

On a bad day — when she did not know who he was, when she was frightened by things he could not identify, when she called for her mother who had been dead for thirty years — he could proceed mechanically: comfort, redirect, manage.

On a good day, when she knew him and talked to him about things she remembered, he was required to be present in a different way — not as a carer, but as a husband.

This required more from him than the management of crisis.

It required him to be glad without performing gladness.

It required him to be in the relationship rather than attending to it.

He was not always sure these were the same person.

Vocabulary Support

proceed mechanically	mekanik olarak ilerlemek
carer	bakıcı
redirect	yönlendirmek

gladness	sevinç
crisis	kriz
same person	aynı kişi

Good days required him to be a husband, not a carer. He was not always sure he was still the same person.

Page 7 — The Memory Clinic

The memory clinic appointments were every three months.

He had found, initially, that the clinical context — the assessment rooms, the waiting areas, the tests that measured what had been retained and what had been lost — produced in him a distress that he managed by taking detailed notes.

He was an engineer. Detailed notes were a form of control.

He understood, after a year, that the notes were also a form of distance — a way of participating in an experience while not fully being inside it.

The consultant had asked him, at the year-two assessment, how he was managing.

'Adequately,' he had said.

She had looked at him.

'That,' she had said, 'is not the same as well.'

Vocabulary Support

clinical context	klinik bağlam
consultant	uzman doktor
adequately	yeterli biçimde
detailed notes	ayrıntılı notlar
participating in	... e katılmak

form of distance	mesafe biçimi
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"Adequately is not the same as well." The consultant saw him. He had not expected this.

Page 8 — What He Had Lost

He had lost, over three years, things he had not known he had.

He had lost the person who knew him best.

Margaret had known him — in the way that only someone who had been present for forty-two years of the making and unmaking of a person could know them — better than he knew himself.

This knowledge was not gone entirely — it was in her still, in fragments, visible on the good days in the way she still knew his particular habits of thought and movement.

But it was no longer accessible to either of them in the continuous, navigable way it had been.

He had lost the ability to be known.

He had not understood, until he lost it, that this was something he depended on.

Vocabulary Support

navigable	seyredilebilir
in fragments	parçalar halinde
accessible	erişilebilir
forty-two years of the making of a person	kırk iki yıllık kişi oluşumu
depended on	güvendi, dayanıyordu

lost the ability	kaybetti
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He had lost the ability to be known. He had not understood, until he lost it, that he depended on it.

Page 9 — Carla's Question

Carla had asked him, in the second year, whether he had thought about additional care — a day programme, perhaps, or a care home.

He had said: 'Not yet.'

This was, he had known when he said it, less of an answer than Carla deserved.

He had thought about it. He thought about it often. He had concluded, each time, that the routines he had built were sufficient for the moment, and that Margaret was, in the environment of their home, better than she would be elsewhere.

He had also concluded, in a thought he had not shared with Carla, that the care of her was, for him, the work that remained.

He was sixty-eight. He had retired. The caring was not a sacrifice of something else. It was the thing itself.

He was not sure he could have explained this to Carla in a way that would not sound like martyrdom.

Vocabulary Support

care home	bakımevi
day programme	gündüz programı
martyrdom	şehitlik, fedakârlık

sufficient	yeterli
the work that remained	kalan iş
concluded	vardığı sonuç

The caring was the work that remained. Not martyrdom. He could not explain the difference to Carla.

Page 10 — The Garden

The garden had, over three years, become the most reliable site of connection.

Margaret could not always tell him where she was, or what day it was, or who Carla was on Carla's visits.

In the garden, she knew the plants by their names and moved among them with a proprietorial ease that was, he had come to think, the purest expression of who she had been.

She had always been the garden person. He had always been the house person.

He had not, before the illness, understood that this division had been one of the structures that organised their life.

He grew things now — not well, not with her knowledge, but he grew them.

It was a conversation they could have without language.

Vocabulary Support

proprietorial ease	sahiplenici rahatlık
reliable site	güvenilir alan
connection	bağlantı
organise	düzenlemek
division	bölünme, ayırım

without language	dil olmaksızın
<i>A conversation without language. The garden gave them this.</i>	

Page 11 — A Tuesday in March

On a Tuesday in March of the third year, she had known him.

Not just in the background way of routine familiarity — she had known him with the forward, present quality of recognising.

She had said, over breakfast: 'Peter. You look tired.'

He had thought: it has been three years. Of course I look tired.

He had said: 'I'm all right.'

She had looked at him the way she had always looked at him when she did not believe what he was saying.

He had not seen that look in a long time.

He had, to his considerable surprise, begun to cry.

She had put her hand on his and said nothing, which was what she had always done.

Vocabulary Support

background familiarity	arka plan tanışıklığı
forward, present quality	ileriye dönük, mevcut nitelik
recognising	tanıma
considerable surprise	büyük şaşkınlıkla
began to cry	ağlamaya başladı

done nothing

hiçbir şey yapmadı

She put her hand on his and said nothing. She had always done this. He had forgotten she knew.

Page 12 — The Long Way Round

He had thought, in the early years of the illness, that what he was experiencing was loss — progressive, irreversible loss of the person he had been with for forty-two years.

He had not been wrong.

What he had not anticipated was that loss, in this form, was not only subtraction.

There were things he had come to know about Margaret — about what she retained, about what she returned to, about what, in the deepest sense, she was — that he had not known before the illness.

The disease had stripped away the accumulations — the habits and performances and assumptions of a long shared life — and had left, in certain moments, something underneath.

He was not sure he would have chosen this way of knowing it.

It was, nonetheless, knowledge.

Vocabulary Support

irreversible	geri dönülemez
subtraction	çıkarma
accumulations	birikimler
stripped away	soymuş

assumptions	varsayımlar
nonetheless	yine de

Loss was not only subtraction. The disease stripped away accumulations and left something underneath.

Page 13 — Carla Again

Carla had come down in the spring and had, on this visit, asked him the question she had been building up to for some time.

She had said: 'Are you happy?'

He had considered this properly.

'I think,' he said, 'that's not quite the right question for the situation. I'm — engaged. There are good days. There are things that happen that I value. But the category of happy is a category that doesn't quite fit.'

Carla had looked at him.

'What does fit?' she asked.

He thought. 'Present,' he said. 'I think what fits is present. I am, most of the time, fully here.'

'And that's enough?' 'It's what there is,' he said. 'Which is different.'

Vocabulary Support

building up to	... için hazırlanmak
engaged	meşgul, bağlı
category	kategori
fully here	tamamen burada
considered properly	düzgünce düşündü
what there is	mevcut olan

"Present. Fully here." Not happy. Present. He understands the difference.

Page 14 — The Fourth Year

In the fourth year, the disease progressed in ways that required — not a care home, for which neither of them was ready, but a change in the level of support.

A carer came three mornings a week: a woman named Grace who had, within two visits, established with Margaret the kind of practical warmth that Peter had observed was common in people who had spent years doing this work.

He had thought he might find Grace's presence difficult.

He found it, instead, like many things in the four years, not what he had anticipated.

He found it clarifying.

He could, on the three mornings, leave the house for two hours.

He had forgotten, until he was given them back, what two hours alone felt like.

Vocabulary Support

progressed	ilerledi
practical warmth	pratik sıcaklık
clarifying	açıklayıcı
two hours alone	iki saatlik yalnızlık
level of support	destek düzeyi

common in people who

... den insanlarda yaygın

He had forgotten what two hours alone felt like. Grace gave them back. He found this clarifying.

Page 15 — What He Did With the Hours

He walked.

He had always been, by preference, a sedentary person — not lazy, but inclined to work rather than physical movement for its own sake.

He walked in the mornings when Grace was there, and found, over the weeks, that walking was a form of thinking that sitting did not produce.

He thought about Margaret, naturally. He also thought about other things — the structure of what he was doing, what would be required in the months ahead, what he thought about his own life at sixty-eight.

He had not asked himself that last question for four years.

He was not sure, having started asking it again, whether the answers were good.

He was glad, nonetheless, to be asking.

Vocabulary Support

sedentary	hareketsiz, durağan
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"Glad to be asking." He had stopped asking questions about his own life. Now he has started again.

Page 16 — What the Consultant Said

At the four-year assessment, the consultant asked him again how he was managing.

He said: 'Better than adequately. I won't say well. But better than adequately.'

She had, he noticed, a small and professional expression of satisfaction.

'What changed?' she asked.

'Several things,' he said. 'I stopped treating the maintenance of the routines as the goal. The goal is her. The routines are in service of that, not substitutes for it.'

'Is there a difference in practice?' 'Sometimes not,' he said. 'But there is a difference in what I'm paying attention to. And that changes what I notice.'

The consultant wrote something.

'I'd like to quote you on that,' she said. 'For trainees.'

'You're welcome to,' he said. He meant it.

Vocabulary Support

professional expression of satisfaction	mesleki memnuniyet ifadesi
in service of	... in hizmetinde

substitutes for	... in yerine geçen
paying attention to	... e dikkat etmek
trainees	stajyerler
maintenance	bakım

"The routines are in service of the goal, not substitutes for it." He found this distinction in four years of caring.

Page 17 — Grace

He had asked Grace, after several months, what she found most difficult about the work.

She had thought about this without deflecting, which he appreciated.

She said: 'The part where the family wants the person to be who they were, and the person is being who they are, and those are two different things. I don't find the person with dementia difficult. I find the family's grief difficult. Not because it's wrong — it isn't — but because it's sometimes in the way.'

He had looked at her.

'In the way of what?' 'In the way of the person who's actually there,' she said. 'There's someone there. They're not who they were. But they're someone.'

He thought about Margaret in the garden.

'Yes,' he said. 'I know.'

Vocabulary Support

deflecting	savuşturmak
grief	yas
in the way of	... nin önünde engel oluyor
dementia	bunama
who they were	kim olduklarını
who they are	kim olduklarını

"There's someone there. Not who they were. But someone." He thought of Margaret in the garden.

Page 18 — The Fifth Tuesday

In the fifth year, there were fewer Tuesdays.

He had, by that point, stopped waiting for them — not in a spirit of resignation, but because the waiting had been, he understood, a way of orienting himself towards the past rather than the present.

He was trying, as best he could, to be present to who she was rather than who she had been.

This was not easy.

It was, he had come to believe, the most important thing.

It was also, he thought, what she would have told him to do.

He had found this thought useful.

He had found it useful not because it was true — he did not know whether it was true — but because it was the thought he could act on.

Vocabulary Support

resignation	kabullenme, boyun eğme
orienting towards	... e yönelmek
present to who she was	kim olduğuna mevcut olmak
useful	faydalı
act on	... e göre hareket etmek
fewer Tuesdays	daha az Salı

Not because it was true — but because it was the thought he could act on. He chose it deliberately.

Page 19 — Carla at the End of the Fifth Year

Carla had come down in the autumn of the fifth year.

She was, he noticed, less agitated than she had been — not because the situation was less serious, but because she had, he thought, made some accommodation with it.

She had sat in the garden with Margaret for two hours, which was the most sustained time they had spent together in a year.

He had watched from the kitchen window, not intrusive but present.

He had thought: Carla is learning to be with her mother rather than with her memory of her mother.

He had thought: I should tell her this is what I have been learning too.

He had not said it.

He thought perhaps it did not need to be said.

Vocabulary Support

accommodation	uyum, uzlaşma
sustained	kesintisiz
intrusive	müdahaleci
present	mevcut, hazır
agitated	huzursuz

made some accommodation	bir uyum sağlamış
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Learning to be with her mother rather than the memory of her. He is learning the same thing. It did not need to be said.

Page 20 — The Long Way Round

He had described it, to a friend who had asked how he was managing, as the long way round.

The friend had asked what he meant.

He had thought about how to say it.

'I mean,' he said, 'that I have been learning something about what a marriage is that I would not have learned through the normal passage of a marriage. The disease has taken away the normal passage. What's left, in certain moments, is not less than what was there — it's different. It has taken me five years to understand that it was possible for the difference to be something rather than simply a subtraction.'

'Can it be both?' his friend asked.

'Yes,' he said. 'Most important things can be both.'

He went home.

The garden was in the late afternoon light.

Margaret was in it.

He went out to join her.

Vocabulary Support

normal passage	normal geçiş
subtraction	çıkarma

both	her ikisi de
late afternoon light	öğleden sonraya dönme ışığı
most important things	en önemli şeyler
something rather than	... dan fazlası

"Most important things can be both." Loss and something. He goes out to join her.

ACTIVITIES

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase	Meaning
1. demarcation	A. sınır çizgisi
2. diagnosis	B. teşhis
3. sedentary	C. hareketsiz
4. proprietorial	D. sahiplenici
5. irreversible	E. geri dönülemez
6. accumulation	F. birikim
7. adequate	G. yeterli
8. resignation	H. kabullenme

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

present — knowledge — known — routine — subtraction — someone

1. Peter had lost the ability to be _____ — he had not realised how much he depended on it.
2. He came to see that loss was not only _____ — the disease revealed something underneath the accumulations.
3. He told Carla he was not happy but _____ — fully here, which was different.

4. He said the routines were in service of the goal, not _____s for it.

5. Grace said there's _____ there — not who they were, but someone.

6. The disease stripped the accumulations and left, in certain moments, _____.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Margaret's Alzheimer's was diagnosed before any symptoms appeared. ____
2. Margaret retains the ability to remember the names of her grandchildren. ____
3. Peter is enthusiastic about additional care from the beginning. ____
4. On the Tuesday in March, Margaret cries and asks for her mother. ____
5. Grace helps Peter by giving him two hours alone, three mornings a week. ____
6. At the end, Peter describes the experience as 'the long way round.' ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why does Peter say that good days are sometimes harder than bad days?
8. What does Peter say he had lost that he had not known he had?
9. What does Peter tell the consultant has changed between year two and year four?
10. What does Grace say that Peter finds clarifying about dementia care?
11. What does Peter mean when he says the caring was 'the work that remained'?

12. How does Peter describe the difference between 'present' and 'happy' to Carla?
13. What does Peter notice about Carla in the autumn of the fifth year?
14. What does Peter mean by describing the experience as 'the long way round'?
15. What does the final scene suggest about what Peter has learned?

ANSWER KEY

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-A 2-B 3-C 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. known 2. subtraction 3. present 4. substitute 5. someone 6. knowledge

True / False: 1. F 2. T 3. F 4. F 5. T 6. T

7. On a bad day he can proceed mechanically — comfort, redirect, manage. On a good day he must be present as a husband, not a carer, which requires being in the relationship rather than attending to it.

8. The ability to be known — Margaret had known him better than he knew himself. He had not understood, until he lost it, that he depended on being known.

9. He stopped treating the maintenance of routines as the goal. The goal is her; the routines are in service of that, not substitutes for it. This changes what he pays attention to and what he notices.

10. Grace says the family's grief is sometimes in the way — in the way of the person who's actually there. The person with dementia is not who they were, but they are someone.

11. He had retired and had no other major work — the caring was not a sacrifice of something else, it was the thing itself. The remaining purpose of his working life.

12. Happy is a category that doesn't fit the situation. Present fits — being fully here, fully engaged. This is what there is, which is different from saying it is sufficient.

13. She is learning to be with her mother as she is, rather than with the memory of who her mother was. Peter is learning the same thing. He thinks it does not need to be said.

14. He has learned something about what a marriage is that the normal passage of a marriage would not have taught. The disease removed the normal passage and revealed something different — not less, but different.

15. He goes out to join Margaret in the garden — he is being present to who she is, not grieving who she was. The evening light, the garden, and going to join her: these are what the long way round has led to.